



Narwhal

Monodon monoceros

Narwhals are unique among whales in having a single long tusk, which is grown mostly by males. The tusk is, in fact, an elongated canine tooth that erupts mainly from the left side of the animal's upper jaw. It grows in a counterclockwise spiral, and is believed to be the reality behind the unicorn legends of medieval Europe.

While scientists once believed that the tusk's function was purely defensive, relating to dominance disputes over mating rights, recent research has revealed millions of nerve endings at the tusk's surface. These nerve endings allow the narwhal to detect changes in water pressure and temperature, as well as degrees of water salinity (saltiness). This discovery suggests that the characteristic rubbing of tusks by males may be a sensation- or information-seeking exercise—not simply "jousting." Tusks can grow to over 8 ft (2.5 m) long and are highly flexible, bending up to 1 ft (30 cm) in any direction without breaking. If a tusk is broken, new growth repairs the damage.

Super pods

Sociable animals, narwhals form small groups that often merge with others to form "super pods" of hundreds of whales. Individuals communicate by clicks, squeaks, and other vocalizations. Pods migrate each year, spending winters in and around the pack ice of the Arctic Ocean, and summers closer inland in bays or deep fjords. Their diet consists mainly of fish, such as halibut and cod, supplemented by squid.



Narwhals can **dive to remarkable depths**, some reaching **5,900 ft (1,800 m)**

△ TIGHT SQUEEZE

Restricted space can cause pods of narwhals to merge as they swim along narrow channels that have opened in the sea ice.

▷ UNICORNS OF THE SEA

Male narwhals surface with their tusks pointing skyward. The dark staining is caused by algal growth.

